WORLD WAR II



THE BATTLE OF LEYTE GULF

Date	October 23–26, 1944
Location	The Philippines
Result	Allied victory

COMBATANTS

US AND AUSTRALIA	JAPAN

COMMANDERS

William Halsey **Thomas Kinkaid**	**Takeo Kurita, Jisaburo Ozawa, Shoji Nishimura**

FORCES

Ships: 35 carriers, 12 battleships, 24 cruisers, 141 other ships	**Ships:** 4 carriers, 9 battleships, 19 cruisers, 34 other ships

LOSSES

Ships: 3 carriers, 4 other ships	**Ships:** 4 carriers, 3 battleships, 8 cruisers, 10 destroyers

THE BATTLE OF LEYTE GULF

On October 20, 1944, US forces began landing on Leyte island as the first stage in the invasion of the Philippines. Admiral Thomas Kinkaid's 7th Fleet was responsible for the amphibious operation, while Admiral William Halsey's 3rd Fleet was on hand to help resist any effort by the Japanese navy to disrupt the invasion. Japan had in fact drawn up plans to meet this contingency and these were swiftly implemented. Virtually all available Japanese naval forces were to be thrown into a death-or-glory battle on an awesome scale.

By this stage in the war, after the disaster of the battle of the Philippine Sea, Japan had few carriers and barely any carrier aircraft, but still possessed a formidable tonnage of large battleships and cruisers. These would have to rely on land-based aircraft from the Philippines for air cover. The Japanese plan, Operation Sho-Go, envisaged simultaneous thrusts by Admiral Takeo Kurita's Center Force through the Sibuyan Sea and Admiral Shoji Nishimura's Southern Force through the Sula Sea, emerging to the east of the Philippines to catch Kinkaid's ships in a pincer from north and south. Admiral Ozawa's force of four impotent aircraft-less carriers was to provide a suicidal decoy for the Americans, drawing some of their fleet away to the north. The plan was ambitious, complex, and very unlikely to succeed.

THE BATTLES BEGIN

Admiral Kurita's Center Force, with five battleships including the giants *Yamato* and *Musashi*, set out for the Philippines on October 22. It suffered its first losses within 24 hours when two of its heavy cruisers, including Kurita's flagship *Atago,* were sunk by American submarines. When he had been picked up out of the sea, the admiral shifted his flag to *Yamoto* and pressed on, entering the Sibuyan Sea on October 24. There his ships were spotted by Halsey's carrier aircraft and an air-sea battle commenced. Japanese aircraft based on Luzon succeeded in destroying the light carrier *Princeton* at great cost to themselves in aircraft and pilots lost, but they could not prevent waves of American carrier aircraft striking the Japanese fleet, putting 19 bombs and 17 torpedoes into *Musashi* before the leviathan finally sunk.

At this point the Americans made an error that could have cost them dearly. Believing that Kurita had turned back to escape air attack, Halsey departed

